Doing Good Business? Design Leaders' Perspectives on Ethics in Design

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Design is not neutral but involves ethical aspects, from addressing power dynamics to enabling broader accessibility and inclusion. In industry settings, design leaders can play an essential role in promoting ethical design by, for instance, setting visions, developing and advocating values, and providing guidance for design. Through co-design workshops with ten design leaders working in Sweden, we investigated how these professionals envision the cultivation—that is, the development, promotion, and dissemination—of ethically responsible design. Our study outlines what the participants regard as the main problems that stifle ethical design and designing, and how to practically address them. The findings highlight that design leaders consider the lack of awareness about the ethical dimensions of design to be one of the main problems. Additionally, they point to various strategies for addressing the problems, such as communicating compelling reasons for prioritizing ethics, creating inclusive and welcoming spaces for collaborative problem-solving and learning about ethics, and folding ethics into current practices. This could involve, for instance, adding the dimension of ethics to 'design critique' sessions, or re-evaluating portfolio reviews to prioritize diversity in recruitment. We conclude by discussing design leaders' potential for furthering ethically responsible design, and provide a practical tool, a design brief, to support this endeavor.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: design leadership, ethics, cultivating practice

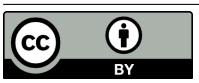
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1 INTRODUCTION

This paper examines design leaders' perspectives on how to cultivate more ethically responsible design within organizational settings, such as design consultancies and design departments. It builds on the notion of ethics as embedded and embodied in practice, co-constructed, and possible to intentionally develop and promote.

Following the so-called "ethical turn" [41, 60], the ethics of design is being increasingly discussed in the literature [16, 18, 26, 47, 69] and by practitioners [4, 6, 20, 31, 46]. Similarly, popular media has shown increased interest in this topic, covering, e.g., how "smart devices" can enable abusers to control, harass, or stalk former spouses [48], how racist bias can result in discrimination in health apps [23], and how AI chatbots can give dangerous advice that can trigger eating disorders [42]. In line with this intensified attention, there is a growing body of academic research and practitioner-led suggestions aiming to advance and investigate ethically responsible design through theories and

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methods [1, 16, 35, 64, 71], manifestos and movements [9, 31], principles [69], books [5, 12, 22, 46], games [45], movies [27, 32], podcasts [30], and networks [21]. Nevertheless, academic contributions have had only limited effect on practice, and a reason for this, according to design practitioners, is that many of these suggestions do not really fit with how things work in industry design practice settings [8, 14, 15, 39, 50]. As a way to further ethically responsible design, and bridge this gap between research and practice, several recent HCI and CSCW studies have inquired into design practitioners' approaches and practices related to ethics [13, 29, 38–40, 51]. More specifically, our previous work [39] has underlined the need for leadership to support and enable practices that are more sensitive to ethical concerns by, for instance, advocating ethical design and introducing and promoting ethics-focused design methods and tools. Still, there remains a need for academics in the fields of HCI and CSCW to develop more comprehensive understandings of design leaders' perspectives on this topic. As design leaders play an important role in setting visions, allocating resources, and defining standard processes [10], they can shape design teams' core values, practices and, thus, the very outcomes of design processes. For these reasons, investigating their perspectives on ethics is an important endeavor, which we have framed through the following research question:

How do design leaders envision the cultivation of ethically responsible design?

A cultivation approach in this context involves the development, promotion, and dissemination of shared ethics that are collectively recognized by professional groups or communities and shape their practice [38, 40]. To explore our research question, we conducted co-design workshops with participants who, at the time of the study, worked and lived in Sweden. We examined the problems and hindrances they perceive in doing more ethically responsible design, and the approaches they suggested to overcome or mitigate these challenges. This provides knowledge from a group of design professionals who have great potential to advance ethical conduct within their communities.

This paper makes three contributions. First, presenting design leaders' articulations of the problems they think can stifle ethically responsible design—i.e., lacking an awareness of ethics in design industry settings, lacking knowledge of how to design ethically, and lacking ethical habits. Second, describing their ideas about how design leaders (including themselves) could address these problems, i.e., developing compelling narratives about ethics, increasing knowledge through collaboration and conversation, and building ethical habits by folding ethics into everyday practices. Third, providing practical insights for reconsidering design leaders' role in promoting ethical practices in design industry, and a practical tool, a design brief, to support this endeavor. Our results can benefit the research and development of design leadership education/training as well as methods and processes supporting ethically responsible design.

2 BACKGROUND

The following three sections provide our points of departure for this research: the understandings of ethics in design practices, the relations between ethics and design leadership, and the notion of "cultivating communities of practice" [67]. This notion takes on a scaffolding and nurturing approach towards change, and it resonates with our framing of ethics as embedded in work practices, as co-constructed, continuously evolving, and as a dimension of design that can be developed, promoted, and disseminated.

2.1 Ethics in design

The impact of how products, systems, and services are designed unquestionably influences individuals, societies, and the planet. This implies ethical responsibility, and, as stated by Verbeek, "If ethics is about the question of how to act, and technologies help to answer this question, technology design is a material form of doing ethics" [65, p. 118]. For example, design has the potential to either uphold or challenge power dynamics, and either perpetuate or dismantle systemic oppression

[16]. Thus, the decisions made by design practitioners regarding which problems to address, the motivations behind these choices, and the individuals or groups to involve or exclude, are all clearly ethical issues [11].

To support and further ethically responsible design, various perspectives and approaches have been suggested, including a large number of ethics-focused design methods and tools stemming from academia as well as from design practitioners in industry [25, 35, 43, 45, 53, 63, 64, 71]. However, the outcomes of academic research have so far had limited adoption within industry settings. Design practitioners have attributed this to the mismatch between these suggestions and the realities of everyday design work. For example, practitioners say that academic resources are not actionable, and rarely provide the clear and simple recommendations that practitioners want [8, 14, 15, 50]. This mismatch points to what has been defined as a research–practice gap.

Several studies have contributed to bridging this gap by studying, from various angles, design practitioners' approaches and practices related to ethics. For example, Gray and colleagues [29] have studied UX practice and ethical mediation. They suggest that several factors play a role in influencing UX practitioners' ethical considerations, and highlight organizational practices, personally held ethical principles, and unique project characteristics. These serve as ethical mediators, either constraining, shaping, or expanding the possibilities for ethically responsible UX design. This means, for instance, that organizational practices can constrain what an individual designer does, but that an individual's actions and advocacy can also change organizational practices. Pillai and colleagues [51] have investigated ethical tensions in UX design, which refers to the ethical challenges that can arise in design projects, for example, when a designer is asked to implement solutions that they consider unethical, such as intentionally making it difficult for users to cancel their subscriptions. They emphasize the importance of creating non-judgmental environments where practitioners can discuss and co-design solutions for dealing with ethical tensions. Moreover, they underscore the role of communities for these discussions, since communities shape attitudes and may influence ethical decision-making. Shilton [59] also supports the need for discussions about ethics in design but in an engineering context, and presents "values levers" that can open such conversations. An example of a values lever is working in an interdisciplinary team, which can stimulate discussions about conflicting values, ultimately influencing the ethical aspects of design. Lindberg and colleagues [39] have explored how design practitioners approach ethics in their practice. The findings note that practitioners call for support for noticing, reflecting on, and reacting to, ethical issues in design, as well as for ethics-focused professional roles that can empower and cultivate the ethical responsibility of the collective. The cultivation of ethics in design is also addressed in a study of how design practitioners at a design studio envision the cultivation of their own ethical practices [38]. The results highlight the importance of discussing ethics in a way that makes sense to designers, the challenge of integrating ethical thinking within an environment driven by profit and metrics, and the need for individuals to feel comfortable and capable of raising ethical concerns at work. Garrett and colleagues [26] have also studied the cultivation of ethics in design and discuss somatic-based ethical sensibilities, conceptualized as "felt ethics". They put forth that somatic-based ethical sensibilities prompt us to act and guide the actions that we take. Thus, they propose that cultivating these sensibilities may be a viable path for furthering ethical design. Another study in this line of research examined an ethics cultivation project at a design studio, with results underscoring how joint inquiry can cultivate ethics in design since it brings forth engagement, diverse voices, and situated knowledge [40]. Moreover, the findings point to the tension between ethics and "business-as-usual" design. Ethics in design has also been discussed in terms of responsibility, often referring to questions of individual responsibility and the distribution of responsibility [49] for the social and environmental outcomes of design. In *The Ethical Design Handbook*, a recently published book authored by design practitioners and intended for "everyone

who works with digital design," ethics is defined as "the duty and responsibility to treat others with fairness and respect" [22, p. xix].

In our study, we refrained from offering a definition of ethics to the participants. Instead, we aimed to explore their own understandings and interpretations of this. However, we did provide a point of view of ethics as co-constructed and changing over time. This aligns with a pragmatist approach to ethics that emphasizes joint inquiry for problem exploration and solution finding [61]. It also aligns with the perspective of "ethos," delineated by Frauenberger, Rauhala and Fitzpatrick [24] as an "embodied and intrinsic set of moral positions that tacitly guides actions and decisions". An ethos shapes practice and practice shapes the ethos in return. All designers and design teams have an ethos and ways of working that are guided (at least partly) by values and beliefs concerning, for instance, what to design ("Should we design for the tobacco industry or not?") and who to design for ("To what extent should we care about accessibility in this project?"). Such values and beliefs are part of the work culture and norms, affecting thought patterns as well as the behavior of design teams, and can be influenced by design leaders.

In summary, research on ethics in design practice has taken varied approaches, including the exploration of ethical mediation [29] and ethical tensions [51]. Additionally, the cultivation of ethics has been studied, where Garrett and colleagues [26] have delved into individual, felt experiences of ethics, while Lindberg and colleagues [38, 40] have focused on organizational aspects and how ethical design can be developed through collaboration and professional roles. Furthermore, various professional roles involved in the design of technology have also been examined regarding ethics in practice, such as engineers [59] and UX designers [29, 38, 51]. We wish to contribute to this body of ethics-in-design-practice knowledge by providing the perspectives of design leaders on cultivating ethics in practice. This professional role has the potential to support ethical conduct within their organization, as their role is inherently influential in shaping the attitudes and behaviors of others.

2.2 Ethics and design leadership

Research on ethics related to leadership has shown that addressing ethical questions is increasingly becoming a foundational subject for many leaders, and that leaders in corporate settings often have intrinsic motivations to engage in ethics, feeling that they have a moral duty towards society [3]. However, they are often also required to support the production of profit, which means that there can be a tension between wanting to do good for the world and expectations of financial gain for the company. Metcalf and colleagues [44] note this tension, and underline that pushing for a more ethical practice sometimes implies contesting core corporate values, while at the same time also being embedded in those exact values, adding complexity and limitations to this endeavor. Still, people in leadership roles have the potential to support ethical conduct within their community by, for instance, vision-setting, resource allocation, and standardization of practice. Moreover, through actions, leaders set examples that can be followed by other employees [17].

More specific to the goals of this paper, "design leadership" is a form of leadership with a primary focus on how design can be used within an organization to accomplish corporate goals [28]. Design leaders and designers often have many things in common, and, many times, design leaders are also designers but with added responsibilities—they are no longer just "playing an instrument" but "conducting the orchestra" as Walter and Woolery put it in their *Design Leadership Handbook* [66, p. 10]. These added responsibilities can encompass, for instance, time allocation, providing strategic vision and guidance for design, promoting methods, tools, and processes for design and design-related activities, and coaching, inspiring, and assisting designers and teams to navigate and understand the challenges they encounter [52]. Through their role, design leaders have many opportunities to communicate important values and to create a "sense of urgency" or "the case for change" [19] towards ethically responsible design.

Bardy [3] highlights social contract theory, which suggests that people's ethos, the "embodied and intrinsic set of moral positions that tacitly guides actions and decisions" [24], arises from agreements and negotiations made to create the society (and work culture) they live in. In a business setting, this can translate into the development and implementation of, e.g., codes of conduct, vision and mission statements, employee handbooks, methods toolboxes, and/or leadership principles. These serve as explicit agreements outlining expectations, responsibilities, and ethical standards for the organization, and design leaders can play an important role in supporting their development as well as promoting and upholding them.

In summary, ethics and design leadership are strongly connected through the responsibility of design leaders to guide people and practices within their organizations.

2.3 Cultivating ethics in practice

This paper builds on the notion of ethics being embedded in practice; what, when, how, and why we do things are informed by our morality (among other things). Furthermore, both our ethics and our practices are constantly in motion and changing over time. This continuous change happens whether we pay close attention to it or not, but can also happen intentionally. Wenger, McDermott and Snyder [67] discuss the changing of practice in terms of "cultivating communities of practice," which is a well-known concept in CSCW and HCI research [36]. Essentially, a community of practice (CoP) is a social group that develops learning and the growth of shared skills and knowledge [37] and consists of a combination of three elements: *domain*, *community*, and *practice*. The *domain* is a domain of knowledge: a topic of interest that creates a common ground and common identity. The *community* refers to the people who create the social fabric of learning and development. The *practice* is what the people are developing to excel in their domain. CoPs usually have a core group of the most active members who drive the community. However, the development of a CoP is not only shaped by this core, but also by the members (current and new) as well as by the continuously changing landscape of practices [68] that they exist in. Moreover, CoPs can transcend organizational boundaries, linking people from different departments or even companies.

Wenger and colleagues [67] discuss "cultivation" in this context and compare it to the tending of plants: "[...] you can do much to encourage healthy plants: till the soil, ensure they have enough nutrients, supply water, secure the right amount of sun exposure, and protect them from pests and weeds." This entails a scaffolding and nurturing approach, and implies that cultivating practice is complex. The complexity of cultivation refers to, for instance, the inherent friction between established disciplinary norms and attempts to change them, "to reorient patterns of knowledge and action" [70, p. 10]. These patterns of knowledge and action are deeply intertwined with, for instance, organizational structures, team dynamics, individual perspectives, business models, and industry standards. Moreover, Wizinsky [70] notes that many design practices today, including technology design practices, are on the brink of a major paradigm shift, since the capitalist foundation that much design in industry relies upon shows signs of cracking. This is an important backdrop to our study, emphasizing the tension between the perspective of design as primarily serving clients' profitability and the perspective of design as contributing to social and environmental well-being.

In summary, in this study, the notion of cultivating communities of practice has provided us with an understanding of design practitioners as members of communities of practice (CoPs), where they share and negotiate ideals, ways of doing things, and visions for the future. Moreover, this framing implies that CoPs can be intentionally cultivated—for instance, by design leaders through their role of providing direction and resources for their design teams. This means that design leaders have ample opportunities to cultivate practice, and, thus, cultivate ethics.

3 METHODOLOGY

To explore design leaders' thoughts on cultivating ethically responsible design, we conducted three runs of a co-design workshop, one in-person and two online, inspired by studies that view co-design as a collaborative process for ethical growth and transformation [41]. Co-design as a methodology emphasizes the importance of involving the people concerned and learning and becoming together, meaning that co-design workshops can also be viewed as sites of exploration and experimentation [54, 55]. This approach resonates with a pragmatist view on ethics, focusing on joint inquiry as a means to explore problems and develop solutions [61].

The in-person workshop had six participants. The first online workshop had three participants. The second online workshop had only one participant, who could not attend any of the other workshops but still wanted to take part in the study. This session had the same structure and covered the same activities as the previous ones (described in Section 3.2). However, since there was only one participant, it was, compared to the other workshops, more like a dialogue with a facilitator. An overview of the method employed by our study is presented in Table 1.

Table 1. Method overview

Participants	Design leaders from design leadership group
Workshop, in-person	2 hours, 6 participants
Workshop, online	2 hours, 3 participants + 1 additional session with a participant who could not attend the other workshops but still wanted to take part in the study
Analysis	Thematic analysis of data from workshops

3.1 Participants

Ten participants were recruited through a Scandinavian design leadership group that is part of the personal network of the first author of this paper. From a CoP [67] perspective, the group's *domain* is design leadership, defined by them as the leading, organizing, and managing of designers. Their *community* consisted (at the time of the study) of 90+ design leaders from different companies as well as governmental institutions, managed by a board of design leaders who drive the community. The group is non-profit and their *practice* aims to support their members in their professional everyday lives through mentorship programs as well as educational and inspirational activities. Participants were recruited by the group through advertisement on their LinkedIn profile, leading to Eventbrite (an event management and ticketing website), where interested group members could enroll using an online form. The sample encompassed diverse kinds of leadership, levels of seniority, and organizational settings. Participation was voluntary and free of charge, and informed consent was obtained. The participants are described in Table 2. Pseudonyms (e.g., P1, P2) are used to ensure the anonymity of the participants and their work contexts.

3.2 Workshop design

This study is part of a larger research project studying ethics in design practice [38–40]. A version of the workshop format this paper draws on had previously been used in the project [38], and was considered to work well for engaging design practitioners in discussing and exploring ethics. The decision to use this format was also supported by two board members from the design leadership group, who participated in the design of the study presented in this paper, who thought the format highly suitable for their community. Moreover, co-design as a methodology is widely used in design

Table 2. Participants

P1 (M)	Competence lead (service and UX design, design leadership), developer, and tech lead at a design consultancy	**P6 (M)**	Design, innovation, and product leadership consultant
P2 (F)	In-house design lead for business development and service design at a global corporation in the retail sector	**P7 (F)**	Competence lead and UX designer in-house at a tech company in the financial sector
P3 (F)	Strategic branding and design, self-employed	**P8 (F)**	Team lead at a global corporation in the retail sector
P4 (F)	In-house design team/project lead at a global corporation in the retail sector	**P9 (F)**	Team lead and product designer in-house at a start-up tech company
P5 (M)	Design lead and creative director at a design and innovation consultancy	**P10 (F)**	UX lead in the governmental sector

research and practice [2, 56, 57], making it a well-established approach for both the authors of this paper and our practitioner participants.

The format we used provides room and structure for group explorations of ethics, and encourages participants to define and explore ethical issues based on their own terminology and experience. The overarching theme of the workshop was "How might we cultivate ethical awareness and ethical practices in design?" The workshops were structured as outlined below.

3.2.1 Introduction. The two facilitators (Authors 1 and 4) opened the workshop by presenting its aims and points of departure. We discussed the point of view of ethics as co-constructed and changing over time and that ethical sensitivity and ethical practices could be cultivated. The workshop was framed as a collaborative space for explorations, intended to remove any felt pressure to be "the expert," and to stimulate an open and relaxed attitude. Consent was collected. Participants briefly introduced themselves (although the participants were part of the same design leadership group, they were not closely acquainted beforehand).

3.2.2 Mapping out ethical problems. Participants brainstormed individually in order to map out ethical problems from their point of view and role as a design leader. We made it clear that a "problem" in this context should be interpreted in a wide sense, being up to the participants to define. We used a set of questions as a starting point: The Actionable Ethics Questions (AEQs), available in appendix A. The AEQs stem from a previous study [38] and are based on issues that designers consider to be ethical challenges at work, such as the ethical responsibilities of individual designers and organizational practices for knowledge sharing about ethics. By engaging with something (an image, question, object, perspective, etc.) the context is framed and provides a common point of departure [58, p. 40]. Using this material as an entry point, instead of an open discussion, was a joint decision made with the group board members involved in the study. We agreed that the AEQs would be a more inspiring start. Participants were directed to use the questions as "triggers" for their brainstorming (and were not expected to read everything in depth). Participants' notes were then discussed in groups. In the in-person workshop, there were two groups of three participants each, the first online workshop had a single group of three participants, and in the third session, the "group" consisted of one participant and the first author.

3.2.3 Prioritizing ethical problems. In the groups, participants quickly negotiated a subset of problems that they considered to be the most important for cultivating ethical design, and that they wished to explore further.

3.2.4 Collectively envisioning solutions. In groups, participants envisioned ways to solve, mitigate, overcome, handle, improve, alleviate, settle, etc., the prioritized problems. This was framed as a "How might we?" exercise, which is well-known in industry settings and used for creative idea generation and problem-solving. In order to stimulate creativity, we provided playful stickers, pens, sticky notes, and different kinds of paper at the in-person workshop. At the online workshops, participants were invited to use the tools built into Google Slides (which was the platform used) for visualizing their ideas. The groups presented their problem–solution pairs and discussed them. In the third (two-person) session, the participant brainstormed solutions and discussed them with the first author.

3.2.5 Wrapping up and looking ahead. The workshop facilitators summarized the workshop, and the results were discussed with the participants. The next step was explaining that a summary of the workshop would be e-mailed to the participants, and that the data would be analyzed for research purposes. Lastly, the participants provided some concluding remarks.

3.3 Data and analysis

We collected the brainstormed and prioritized problems discussed by our participants in the form of sticky notes and scribbles (from the in-person workshop) and as digital notes (from the online sessions). We also collected participants' envisioned "solutions" and audio-recorded when participants presented and discussed what they had worked on (their "problem–solution" combinations). Moreover, the workshop facilitators took research notes throughout the workshops, jotting down ideas, quotes, and issues that seemed especially important and/or had stirred emotions.

The audio recordings of the presentations were transcribed. The transcriptions, research notes, and visual "solutions" were gathered in a document. The authors of this paper conducted a thematic analysis [7] of this document, individually as well as collectively in different constellations and iterations, reading and re-reading, coding and re-coding as we went along, exploring various approaches to interpret and structure the data. During the first round of analysis, we focused on themes concerned with participants' interpretations of ethics, attitudes towards ethics, and the roles of design leaders related to the cultivation of ethics. Following the intent of presenting the participants' perspectives, values, concepts, and points of view, we decided to focus on synthesizing the main problems as discussed throughout the workshops, and link the identified problem areas to participants' discussions on how to address them.

3.4 Reflections on positionality

The first author has extensive professional experience from design industry as a UX and service designer, and is still actively involved in several design communities. This has provided advantages in terms of enrolling participants, and understanding the nuances of their statements. Having worked as design practitioner for more than twenty years has also provided insights into the challenges of juggling business and ethics, which also served as a driving factor to understand this problem through empirical research.

Our aim with this research has been to investigate design leaders' perspectives on cultivating ethically responsible design. Our analysis, however, has not sought to unpack the rightness or wrong-doings of design leaders, but rather to identify their ethical challenges and their ideas for overcoming them.

The design of this study aimed to create mutual benefits for both the research team and the participants. This has also been its motivation. Accordingly, the relations between the research team and the participants have been based on the idea of co-creation, empowerment, collaboration, and the participation and involvement of concerned people [56]. The workshops were designed to serve research goals as well as the participants' interests in the ethics of design, by creating an inspiring and relaxing space for networking, and for engaging discussions on how to advance and nurture more ethical design. Our concern for the participants' interest has also been reflected in the translation of the findings into something that is potentially useful to the study participants: that is, the design brief for the cultivation of ethics presented in Section 5.2.

4 FINDINGS

Our study investigated how design leaders would envision the cultivation of ethically responsible design. To this end, we encouraged participants to discuss what they considered to be the problems that hinder the advancement of ethically responsible design, and to generate ideas for addressing these problems. Based on their discussions, we present our findings in three interconnected themes (see Table 3 for an overview). The leftmost column summarizes the problems identified through participants' discussions and also shows the main themes of the findings. The rightmost column presents a synthesis of the strategies participants envisioned for addressing the problems, also detailed in the findings.

Table 3. Overview of problems and solutions

Problem area	**How the problem could be addressed**
"A lack of awareness"; ethics is not a "normal dimension" in design practice today	Raising awareness through compelling narratives: - Ethically responsible design as a business opportunity - With power comes responsibility
"A lack of knowledge"; designers do not know how to do ethically responsible design	Increasing knowledge through collaboration and conversation: - Safe and inclusive spaces for problem-solving and learning - Framing ethics as desirable - Clients and business partners need to be part of the conversation too
"A lack of ethical habits"; current practices do not pay enough attention to ethics	Building ethical habits by folding ethics into everyday practices: - Adapting current design methods and tools - Concrete and designerly examples - Recruiting with ethics in mind

4.1 "A lack of awareness"; ethics is not a "normal dimension" in design practice today

As was extensively discussed during the workshops, participants reported that many design practitioners in their communities "lack an awareness" of the ethical dimensions of design. This can be seen as connected to the overarching world-view in design industry that the purpose of design is to support corporate goals, meaning that most activities in design industry settings are done in favor of business and profit, while values such as social and environmental well-being, autonomy, or privacy tend to slide into the background. The lack of an awareness of ethics was considered a key problem, since awareness, or the feeling that something is not as it should be, is a crucial, initial step towards bringing about a transformation and taking action.

For design practitioners in different roles, including design leaders, to consider in more depth the potential harm that design can bring about, it is essential for them to be aware that design is not neutral but involves ethical aspects. Being aware of ethics in design would mean, for instance, to have the ability to recognize that a design decision could put users at risk of harassment or exclusion. Participants said that even the few designers who might be aware of the ethical dimensions of design, may still not consider ethics to be their responsibility:

> "[…] a lot of designers, I don't think they really think of ethics, that this is something that they're responsible for, it's not their thing to bring up, to bring to the table. It's someone else's problem. It's the product manager's problem, or the project manager's problem, or the client's problem. So easy to just push away responsibility for it." (P1)

This issue was also discussed in terms of "culture," asking how to reinforce "the culture of ethics":

> "…how do ethics show up in our company culture? Like what rituals exist or do not exist currently that supports that enablement of ethical behavior?" (P4)

The issue of a lack of awareness was discussed in relation to different stakeholders, such as employers, design team members, clients, suppliers, and business partners. The issue was also connected to participants' ideas about responsibility and their own role as design leaders. Since design leaders are responsible for shaping the vision and values of designing, raising awareness about ethics aligns with their role and would elevate the importance of the topic. Design leaders could effectively communicate ethical stances and communicate reasons for prioritizing and actively engaging with ethics.

Accordingly, discussions during the workshops suggested that **raising awareness through compelling narratives** could be a viable way forward in this matter. Two narratives, presented below, were discussed as having the potential to raise awareness and convey to professionals involved in design processes why they should engage in ethically responsible design.

4.1.1 Ethically responsible design as a business opportunity. Participants said that companies that want to stay relevant to their customers need to take ethics into consideration since customers care about ethics. Participant P8 talked about how companies are now paying closer attention to their customers, since in today's competitive landscape and with the power of social media, customer feedback and addressing complaints or ethical concerns have become crucial to maintaining a positive company image:

> "I think also that has forced companies into 'we need to follow where our users are.'" (P8)

Moreover, participants' impression was that a growing number of people are actively looking to work for companies with a good ethical reputation, and engaging in ethics might therefore be necessary for recruitment purposes. Related to this, participants discussed that when companies realize the "business case" for ethically responsible design, for instance ethics as a way to differentiate themselves from competitors and attract clients, companies will start caring more about ethics and ethical design:

> "I think as soon as ethics has been seen as a business case, that people relate ethics to like revenue, it will become top priority in companies." (P4)

This implies that the "ethically responsible design as a business opportunity" narrative might be a compelling one, since it would appeal to the business aspects of design practice—potentially attracting customers, clients, investors, and new employees. Moreover, it could help retain employees who want to work for "ethical companies." This narrative is directed towards the economic realities of business and organizations, and their values and norms. Talking about ethics as a business

opportunity should, however, not be confused with "ethics washing," i.e., using ethical stances as merely a branding strategy or a façade for unethical behavior.

4.1.2 With power comes responsibility. Participants discussed that many designers chose their profession with the intention of making the world a better place, but that somewhere along the way design became "just a job":

> "I think designers become designers because we want to make a difference or change the world, but sort of somewhere along the pathway, it becomes just a job. And having a reminder about that we still have the power to make a difference, I think that's something we need to do more perhaps." (P1)

Holding "power to make a difference" implies that this power should be used for good. For instance, that designers can design for social and environmental well-being and/or to refuse to design. Therefore, the narrative of "with power comes responsibility" might be a compelling one. Participant P5 shared an example of how he already pushes this narrative today as a design leader:

> "[…] when I work with my design team, one thing I keep reminding them is that they are the voice of the voiceless, the people with no power. The only way they [the voiceless] come into the room is through good designers spending time with them, otherwise no one worries about them." (P5)

Design leaders could use this narrative to underscore the power they and other design practitioners hold, along with the ethical responsibilities that come with that power. This could empower and inspire design professionals in various roles to care about ethics, and could strengthen their sense of ethical responsibility.

4.2 "A lack of knowledge"; designers do not know how to do ethically responsible design

A second major problem discussed by our participants was "a lack of knowledge" of how to do ethically responsible design. This connects with the former theme: awareness alone is not enough to stimulate action, knowledge on how to act is also important. How this knowledge should be raised and disseminated, who to engage, and how to engage these individuals, was discussed and considered as crucial aspects. Participants pointed out that people need to feel comfortable and safe in order to engage in learning about ethics, without fear of being ridiculed or judged. They stressed the importance of an inclusive atmosphere for learning activities, where individuals, regardless of their professional role or level of seniority, would feel encouraged to participate and share their points of view. This means that design leaders must ensure that their efforts to increase knowledge about ethics are genuinely inclusive and accommodating of various participants. This necessitates a thorough understanding of people's needs and preferences so that a variety of people join, and not, for example, only the people with the most power. This was stressed by participant P4 with the rhetorical question:

> "[…] how can you make sure that everyone is being seen and heard?" (P4)

In line with this, **increasing knowledge through collaboration and conversation** was suggested by our participants: getting design practitioners together to talk about ethics and ethical dilemmas, learning together, and developing shared understandings and shared ways of working. Furthermore, introducing ethics in design as a shared learning experience could help alleviate design practitioners' felt pressure to be "the expert," potentially making them more comfortable and excited about joining the conversation.

4.2.1 Safe and inclusive spaces for problem-solving and learning. Participants suggested that design leaders could establish and promote space and time for conversations about ethics in design. They

sketched this as a boxing ring, symbolizing a designated time and space for talking and learning, problem-solving—and for potential conflicts (Fig. 1).

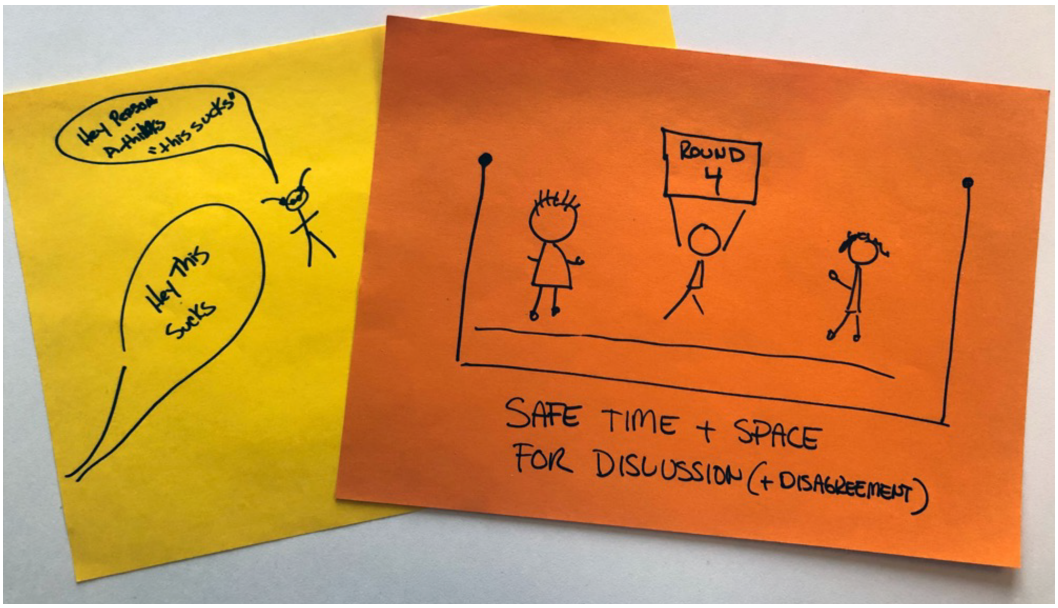


Fig. 1. Participants' sketches from workshop.

Participants granted that the boxing ring can be interpreted as an arena for violence, but this was not what they were after. Instead, the boxing ring was an acknowledgement that ethics involves conflict and tension:

> "Values and ethics are easy until something breaks, and then you need to have a safe space." (P5)

Participant P4 elaborated on the importance of feeling safe, and pointed out the importance of remembering that some colleagues may come from positions of less power. Design leaders need to be mindful of this aspect when creating spaces for discussions:

> "[...] you never know who's with you in the room. And you never know who's been marginalized historically, in that group." (P4)

More concretely, the space could be a format for discussions of ethical dilemmas related to the projects that need deliberation. It might also be sessions for discussing and learning about ethics in design more generally, for instance inviting an ethics expert for an inspirational talk, sharing experiences, or trying out and discussing ethics-focused design methods.

4.2.2 Framing ethics as desirable. Participants stressed that learning about ethics also needs to be perceived as fun and meaningful in order to engage participants and inspire them to want to learn more. This also relates to communication about ethics needing to be audience-specific:

> "What type of communication is most appropriate or suitable for the distribution of design ethics? Because I think, whilst we're asking those questions, it's also, for me, really important to understand: who's the audience of this, this type of information? And how is it accessible for those groups?" (P4)

For example, discussing ethics as "detecting safety risks" might fit in some contexts, while discussing "the ethical responsibilities of a designer" might fit in others. To illustrate their point, participants used the example of Pippi Longstocking, a well-known children's book character in Scandinavia as well as in other parts of the world. Pippi is fun, brave, and strong, making her a popular role model. By incorporating ethical discussions and conflicts within the positive context of Pippi Longstocking, participants suggested that engagement in ethics could be framed as something courageous and enjoyable. As one participant said:

> "[...] if we talk about it like Pippi, then everyone will do it." (P5)

4.2.3 Clients and business partners need to be part of the conversation too. Spaces for exploring and discussing ethics should also include clients and business partners, according to our participants. For example:

> "[...] what do we as a company deem to be ethical or unethical? And what do we deem to be ethical industries, clients, or projects which they will work for or not?" (P4)

These kinds of conversations were considered important both in the sense of internally discussing what clients and business partners to work for and with, and in the sense of talking about ethics *with* clients and business partners. Clients and business partners need to be part of the conversation too in order to make ethical priorities clear, avoid ethical misconduct, and find more ethical solutions.

Talking with clients and business partners about ethics might be even harder than talking to colleagues about it. How should the conversation start? When is it suitable to bring up ethics? How could it be done without you being perceived as "the annoying guy who always brings up ethics" (as participant P1, half-jokingly, described himself)? Design leaders could function as role models for this, normalizing and adding status to bringing up ethics. However, as a consultant, at the end of the day, you work for the client:

> "I can guide, I can give advice, I can make recommendations, but it's up to the customer's, or client's, decision. The only thing I can do, is I can make their decision as informed as possible." (P1)

4.3 "A lack of ethical habits"; current practices do not pay enough attention to ethics

Participants discussed a range of specific practices, encompassing areas such as design as well as recruitment, that could be modified to enhance the support for ethically responsible design, directly as well as indirectly. Values and ethics are ingrained in everyday practices and enacted through practices. Thus, by infusing more ethical considerations into everyday practices, both awareness (theme 1) and knowledge (theme 2) of ethics in design could be advanced. Hence, this is a form of cultivating ethics. Since design leaders are often in charge of standardizing designers' methods and activities, adapting and promoting methods and activities fits with their role. In line with this, **building ethical habits by folding ethics into everyday practices** was suggested by our participants. Adjusting practices-in-use is probably also a lower threshold to change (and more cost-effective) compared to establishing new ways of working. Moreover, by integrating ethical considerations into everyday habits, ethical aspects are less likely to be forgotten or ignored.

4.3.1 Adapting current design methods and tools. "Design crit" is a well-known practice where designers gather to critique design in order to find problems and generate improvements. Participants suggested that ethics could be one of the perspectives to consider in this kinds of session, and that design leaders could promote this addition. Moreover, according to P1's experience, design crit is rather common in UX/UI contexts, while in developer contexts, it is not—developers do not have the practice of presenting their code and letting others scrutinize it. P1 suggested that "ethics in crit" could fit there too:

> "… those of us who are not working with visual representations, we have no such forum to discuss our decisions in, and there could be." (P1)

Ethics-focused questions for a crit session could be, for instance: Who is this design benefiting? Who might it potentially harm? Is this design challenging or perpetuating power dynamics?

Another idea for adaptation was connected to "rituals" (a term used by our participants referring to especially meaningful recurring activities). Design leaders could establish and promote ethics-related rituals that could work as important reminders, for instance, by adding ethics-focused check-in questions for meetings. Moreover, the artefacts used in the day-to-day practices could also be modified to remind designers about ethics, such as using a business model canvas that also includes ethical dimensions:

> "Like there's the revenue, cost, value proposition and such, but where is the … ethical box? And if it's not there, nobody is gonna talk about it building new services." (P6)

This comment shows how the methods and tools commonly used in practice shape what practitioners notice and engage with.

User research and user involvement are often big parts of design work. A suggestion for how to make this more ethical was created at our workshop (Fig. 2).



Fig. 2. Sketch of a tool for inclusive user research: "The Dinosaur Framework".

This tool aimed at reminding designers to think about who gets considered in user research, and who might be excluded, for example at the levels of wealth, health, or gender. The tool aimed at making excluded users and other stakeholders visible. The stickers in the circle represent the users usually included, the other stickers represent potential users to also include:

> "This is where we are in the middle with the norm [pointing to the dinosaurs in the middle], everyone that we used to interview is here. But what about those dinosaurs on the outside?" (P10)

This idea was developed with more details after the workshop. During the workshop it remained a "quick and dirty" and conceptual draft, but still serves as an example of our participants' ways of approaching ethical issues in ways familiar and useful to them.

4.3.2 Concrete and designerly examples. Pinpointing ethical malpractice as well as providing positive examples of ethically responsible design in the form of, e.g., case studies was another suggestion of what design leaders could do. This would be a concrete and designerly way to show designers, clients, and business partners what ethically responsible design (as well as unethical design) might mean, in a format that makes sense in the design context. A related suggestion was to gather and share stories and articles about ethically responsible design, written in a way that makes them easy to grasp for practitioners, i.e., "not academic papers," as explained by participant P9.

4.3.3 Recruiting with ethics in mind. Design leaders with recruitment responsibilities have the option of infusing ethical considerations into the recruitment process. For example, UX/UI designers are often required to provide a portfolio (a show-reel of previous projects) when applying for jobs. Participant P8 stated that bias often affects how design leaders review these portfolios, and that there is a clear tendency to employ more of the same:

> "[...] it's also so much biases around who is getting an employment and not. And people coming from specific schools, and how that also shapes the design that's being created." (P8)

Participants highlighted that a more diverse workforce could increase ethically responsible design, since it would bring a wider array of perspectives to the table and provide a greater chance of detecting ethical problems. However, in order to employ a more diverse workforce, design leaders might have to reconsider how they review portfolios.

Onboarding new employees is often also a design leader's responsibility. Participants pointed out that this often holds a missed opportunity to communicate about ethics; the onboarding process often includes an introduction to the values and practices of the workplace, and talking about ethics would fit into this context.

Participants also suggested hiring experts on ethics. This would communicate that the topic is important and taken seriously, and such an expert could bring knowledge of hands-on methods for dealing with ethics in design. An expert could also criticize current practices, "be the bad guy," and ask difficult questions more freely than other employees might feel qualified to or comfortable doing. A specific expert role that was conceived/discussed was the "CEA," the Chief Ethical Advisor, supporting employees at all levels of an organization to engage in ethical practices. This highlights that ethically responsible design requires the participation of the entire organization.

5 DISCUSSION

In this paper, we have investigated how design leaders see the cultivation of ethically responsible design. Design leaders can play an important role in shaping design practice. Therefore, their perspectives can provide useful insights into how ethically responsible design can be advanced. The findings can also aid in bridging the gap between research and practice [8, 14, 50] by providing understandings that are anchored in practice. We have examined design leaders' perspectives on what they consider to be the main problems/barriers that stifle ethically responsible design as well as their ideas for dealing with these problems. Moreover, the findings provide some insight into what design leaders consider to be important aspects to take into account related to ethics in design, as well as their thoughts on their role as potential cultivators of ethics.

Our findings make visible design leaders' understandings of ethics in design, with diversity and inclusion being recurring topics concerning design teams, processes, and methods. Participants' suggestions for dealing with the problems they identified are directed towards a range of different stakeholders—primarily designers and design leaders, but, in some cases also managers, clients, and business partners—implying that ethically responsible design requires the engagement of design

leaders as well as various stakeholders to which design leaders are connected. Additionally, the problems and solutions discussed in this paper shed light on how the participants perceive the influence and authority of the role of a design leader.

The design leaders who participated in the workshops had an interest in ethically responsible design that preceded the study itself. While probably not representative of the broader, local, design-leadership community, their experiences are indicative of a growing trend (at least in Scandinavia, where the study was conducted) to be more responsive to the ethical challenges of technology design. As design consultancies and design departments integrate ethical issues (e.g., environmental sustainability) even in their business models, our participants' insights point to some of the challenges that might lay ahead. We call for additional studies that explore similar issues in other settings, for instance, in organizations of various sizes, or in socio-cultural contexts where work relations might be structured differently.

5.1 A growing body of ethics-in-design-practice knowledge

Consistent with Frauenberger and colleagues [24], who emphasize the need for a changed work culture that has room and structure for ethos building, participants brought up the notion of safe and inclusive spaces for collaborative problem-solving and learning related to ethics. This has also been suggested by Pillai and colleagues [51]. In addition, people also need reasons to engage. This was addressed by our participants with the strategy of raising awareness, which resonates with previous research, such as the work of Shilton [59] recognizing the need to encourage paying attention to ethics in design, and the noticing–reflecting–reacting approach noted by Lindberg and colleagues [39] underlining how noticing ethical dimensions is a key step for ethical design practice. Two narratives were discussed for raising awareness. One that framed ethical design as being good for business, while the other focused on the notion that with power comes responsibility. All communities have narratives that shape them [68]. Thus, telling new stories is important for shaping new futures, and these narratives could be such new stories, motivating change towards more ethical considerations in design practice settings. A number of suggestions for folding in ethics into current practices were also discussed, such as adding ethics as a perspective in "design crits," and recruiting with ethics in mind: intended to bring about a broader range of perspectives through a more diverse workforce, thereby increasing the likelihood of identifying and addressing ethical concerns. Kapania and colleagues [33] acknowledge that this particular issue is easier said than done and note that true diversity needs to go beyond representationalist thinking.

The suggestions presented at our workshops were not fully developed. Revisiting the cultivation metaphor, they are "seedlings" that need further nurturing, and due to the difficulty of breaking old habits and re-routinizing changed behavior, any suggestion for change would most likely also need long-term advocacy, follow-up, and positive reinforcement. Moreover, the suggestions from our workshop confirm research noting that solutions from practice often focus on operationalizing ethics in the gaps in practice [44]. On the one hand, this implies that the suggestions may be "confined" inside current practices and norms, potentially making them less innovative. On the other hand, staying "inside the box" also implies that the suggestions might fit well in practice. This is important, since previous research has noted that many solutions for advancing ethically responsible design are underused in practice and that a reason for this might be that they do not fit with how things work in industry settings [8, 14, 50]. As Stolterman [62] put it: "any attempt to introduce a new 'rationality' into practice has to resonate with the already existing rationality." An existing "rationality" in design industry today is the "business-as-usual" design paradigm, where design's primary role is to support business needs [70]. This means that if design leaders were to introduce adjusted ethics-focused methods, time and space for learning about ethics, adapted recruitment processes for considering diversity in recruiting, etc., these changes need to relate

to the overarching rationality of profit-making, which can make it tricky to argue for ethical responsibility. This seems to be an important tension, that would benefit from further investigation.

Today, design leaders play an essential role in supporting the use of design within organizations to achieve corporate goals. This organizational emphasis is evident in both our participants' discussions and supported by existing literature [28]. However, our findings also highlight the fact that design leaders have ample opportunities for advancing ethically responsible design. Their influential role gives them the authority to shape design processes, methodologies, and practices. Their deep understanding of the design process allows them to integrate ethical considerations throughout the design process. Their championing of ethical values can help shape a community that prioritizes ethically responsible design.

Still, design leaders may face challenges in such an endeavor. They might encounter resistance from stakeholders who prioritize financial gains or the "traditional" design approaches over ethical considerations. Moreover, design leaders themselves may lack the necessary awareness, knowledge, and resources to promote ethics in design, and the pressure to meet tight deadlines and deliver results might lead to compromises on ethical aspects. This means that while design leaders can indeed make a difference, the challenge remains significant.

5.2 Sparking conversations on ethics in design

Our participants said that ethics needs to move more into the foreground, since there is a "lack of awareness" of ethics in design industry. According to their explanations, other concerns, such as profit, often have precedence over the societal impact of design decisions. Therefore, sometimes even starting the conversation can be challenging.

As a way to address this, responding to Norman's call for translational developers [50], and fulfilling our participants' wish for concrete and designerly examples (mentioned above), we have used our findings to develop a conversation starter/prompt. This is intended as a way to produce research outcomes that might be useful to both the participants in this study and the broader design community. It is based on insights from our study and aims to help design leaders cultivate ethical awareness and responsibility in their design communities.

The format of the conversation starter aligns with methods designers are already familiar with, by drawing on the design brief format, which is a common way to start a design project in the industry. Kapkın and Joines [34] describe design briefs as a priming/framing stimulus that typically provides an overview of a problem or objective, target audience, project scope, product category, timeline, and budget. Design briefs are approached through group/team work, collaboratively unpacking the problem and solution space. As such, they are a way to facilitate and conduct joint inquiries, which is the methodological underpinning of this choice. Moreover, introducing design briefs as a team exercise is fitting for the design leader role, as they are often responsible for promoting design methods, tools, and processes within the organization. However, as noted in our findings, design practitioners (including design leaders) rarely read academic papers. Therefore, we have also packaged this idea as Google Slides (https://tinyurl.com/sparkingethics) intended to fit with practice, be actionable, and easy to understand and use—which are also some of the qualities that design practitioners in other studies have emphasized as important [14]. Moreover, we have strived to keep the language in the brief uncomplicated and free from academic jargon, and have kept the layout and visual style simple, intending to making the slides easy to adapt and use for anyone.

The brief (Fig. 3) includes an introduction, where some foundations are spelled out. For example, that design is not neutral, and that ethics is co-constructed and changes over time. Moreover, the purpose of the brief is noted, emphasizing that it is intended to get the conversation on ethics going. Next follows the actual design brief, connected to raising awareness. The brief consists of five parts.

First, the *what*, the challenge (Fig. 3), introducing the need for design practitioners to engage in ethically responsible design. The main issue that the brief revolves around is "How might we raise/increase awareness of ethically responsible design?"



Fig. 3. Start slide and brief challenge. Entire brief available at https://tinyurl.com/sparkingethics

Second, the *who*, the target audience, presenting "designers," "managers," and "clients and business partners" (the stakeholders noted in our findings) as three potential audiences to focus on. Reflective questions related to this ask "Who, more precisely, in the target audience, do we need to engage

in order to raise the awareness of ethics in design? What's in it for them to engage? What do we want them to think, feel, do?"

Third, the *how*, asking participants to ideate ways to raise the awareness for the target audience. To get the creative juices flowing, a number of optional starting points for the ideation is presented, e.g., an interactive art installation, a storytelling adventure, a design manifesto, and a speculative piece of furniture.

Fourth, the *when*, allowing some space for thinking about the realization of the idea. Participants are asked to outline their idea as a project with a timeline and some preliminary budget considerations.

Fifth, the grand finale, a project pitch. Participants are asked to express their understanding of the challenge, share relevant insights about their chosen target audience, present and pitch their "grand idea," and outline a timeline and budget for realizing their project proposal.

The brief is conceptualized as "Sparking conversations on ethics in design" and is intended as a "useful first." We warmly welcome both practitioners and researchers to expand on this idea.

6 CONCLUDING REMARKS

We have provided an account of how a group of design leaders working in Sweden have discussed the problems that they consider stifle ethically responsible design, and what design leaders could do about it. The key problem was considered to be an overall lack of awareness of the ethical dimensions of design. Thus, we conclude that design leaders who wish to cultivate ethics in design need to start with raising the awareness of ethics in design, since this is the crucial initial step towards bringing about transformation and taking action. To aid raising this awareness, we have produced a design brief intended to support starting conversations on ethics in design. The brief might also be useful for researchers looking to develop ethical design practices.

More research is needed to understand the role of motivation/rationale for design leaders in "business-as-usual" design contexts to engage in ethics as a shared ethos cultivation. Other intriguing possibilities for future studies include inquiring into how design leadership outside of Scandinavia, which might have other traditions of leadership, consider problems and solutions for ethically responsible design. Lastly, it would be valuable to explore how our participants' suggestions would pan out in an industry practice setting.

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